WEEK 1 · LESSON 5 OF 24 · HANDOUT

AI in Rwanda and Across Africa

Study time: **about 40 minutes** (reading, video and activity)

Your goal in this lesson: Describe how AI is already being used in Rwanda and Africa, explain why local data and languages matter, and identify opportunities in your own field.

AI is not only a Silicon Valley story

Some of the most practical uses of technology in the world are happening in Africa, because the problems are real and the need is urgent. Rwanda in particular has made digital transformation a national priority, and in **2023 the Government of Rwanda adopted a National Artificial Intelligence Policy** to guide the safe and useful adoption of AI across the economy.

Examples close to home

- **Health logistics** — Rwanda has used drones (Zipline) since 2016 to deliver blood and medical supplies to hospitals in hard-to-reach areas, using software to plan routes and manage demand.
- **Agriculture** — AI tools can identify crop diseases from a phone photo, forecast weather, and help farmers plan planting and fertiliser use.
- **Financial services** — mobile-money and banking systems use machine learning to detect fraud and assess credit for people without a long banking history.
- **African languages** — communities such as **Masakhane** build language technology for African languages, and **Digital Umuganda** has collected Kinyarwanda voice data so speech technology can understand Kinyarwanda speakers.
- **Education** — AI tutors and study assistants help learners practise at their own pace.
- **Research and talent** — the **Deep Learning Indaba** brings together thousands of African AI researchers and students, and Kigali hosts international technology and AI events.

Why local data and languages matter

An AI tool trained mostly on English text from other countries may:

- misunderstand Kinyarwanda, Swahili or French mixed with English;
- give advice that fits another country's laws, prices or culture;
- know little about Rwandan institutions, places and history.

That is why **local data, local languages and local experts** are so valuable — and why there are real jobs and businesses to be built by people who understand both AI and the local context.

Opportunities by field

Field	Where AI can help
Education	Lesson planning, practice questions, feedback on writing
Health	Appointment reminders, record summaries, health information in local languages
Agriculture	Disease detection, weather and market-price information
Business	Customer service, marketing content, bookkeeping help
Government services	Faster answers to citizens, document processing
Tourism & hospitality	Multilingual guest communication, booking support

A balanced view

AI also brings real challenges for Africa: the cost of internet and devices, protecting personal data, avoiding tools that do not fit local needs, and making sure benefits reach everyone, not only big cities. Good professionals keep both the opportunity and the risk in view.

Remember this: AI is already solving real problems in Rwanda and Africa, and people who understand the local context are exactly the people needed to use it well.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Activity

Task 1

Pick your field (or the field you want to work in).

Task 2

Write down **two problems** in that field in Rwanda that AI might help with.

Task 3

For each problem, write: the data that would be needed, who would benefit, and one risk to watch out for.

Self-check

Think about your answers here, then take the quiz online — it is marked instantly and explains every answer.

1. In which year did Rwanda adopt its National Artificial Intelligence Policy?
   A. 2016
   B. 2023
   C. 2019
   D. 2030
2. What has Zipline been doing in Rwanda since 2016?
   A. Running a social network
   B. Delivering blood and medical supplies by drone
   C. Teaching coding in schools
   D. Selling smartphones

3. Why is Kinyarwanda voice data, like Digital Umuganda's, important?

A. It is only used for music

B. It replaces English completely

C. It makes phones cheaper

D. It helps speech technology understand Kinyarwanda speakers

4. What is the Deep Learning Indaba?

A. A gathering that strengthens African AI research and talent

B. A type of AI model

C. A Rwandan bank

D. A government law

5. Why might a general AI tool give poor advice about Rwandan regulations?

A. It is illegal to ask

B. AI cannot read numbers

C. It was trained mostly on data from other countries and may lack local details

D. Rwandan regulations are secret

6. Which is a real CHALLENGE for AI adoption mentioned in this lesson?

A. AI only works in rural areas

B. Protecting personal data and making sure benefits reach everyone

C. Too many free devices

D. There are no problems to solve

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